



Who made it **big** in Open Source

Who says there's no money in Open Source? We tell you the 'how' part in another cover story, but here's the 'who' side of the story. Strap yourself in for an in-depth look at some of the rockstars of Open Source did quite well

Siddharth Parwatay

siddharth.parwatay@thinkdigit.com

Most of us as end-users of Open Source Software (OSS) are very comfortable using it. And it's not simply because the products are built well or that using them keeps you away from piracy. There's another reason, operating at a more sub-conscious level. Search within yourselves and you'll realise that a small part of you is happy about using OSS since you feel you're not adding to someone's coffers. You fire up Firefox everyday content that no big evil corporation is getting rich off of you. The truth, however, is a little different. Like we've explained several times in this cover story section, free in open source doesn't mean free of cost but rather freedom. Hence, in actuality there are lots of people making money from Open Source one way or another.

Blake Ross

Now 26, Blake Ross was a young kid when he started off as an intern with Netscape years ago. Not happy with the direction Netscape was taking under AOL, he started Firefox as a renegade project under the Mozilla banner. What emerged from it was an easy-to-use browser that was free to download,



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easy to use, safe and not Microsoft. Within the first year itself, the browser was downloaded more than a hundred million times. While Mozilla is a non-profit foundation, it's still a rich foundation. Most of the world thinks Mozilla survives on generous donations, but the most significant part of its

income comes from corporate deals. It was said that 80 per cent of its revenues came from a long standing deal with Google. Did you honestly think the custom search engine on the default home page and that little search bar was altruism? Mozilla's revenues for the year 2009 were to the tune of \$104 million. Now coming back to our boy wonder Blake Ross. We don't exactly know the details of the arrangement he has with the foundation, but his reported net worth is around \$150 million. And the journey to this stage began when he was just out of his teens. Maybe he was like any other developer working on the project and no cheques were directly written to him, or perhaps it was some angel investor who saw potential; clearly it pays to have co-



Matt Mullenweg